

said. "Nothing, that is, if you are going to do it once. But if you make a habit of it, and start buying and selling stocks as a business, then you have to be registered as a securities dealer. Those are the facts of the situation."

Before I could get any further with this, I saw a TV ad for *Barron's* magazine in which the editor said: "You buy a stock convinced it is going to go up. The trouble is, the person you bought it from is just as convinced it's going to go down." I realized then that the garage sale idea was impractical. If I met the sellers of Angstrom face-to-face, they'd probably tell me it was a lousy company with no sales department and no hope of getting a government contract. We'd argue and argue and never come to any agreement, or if we did agree, then there'd never be a stock sale.

If I were trying to sell you my Angstrom, for instance, then you'd want to know why. If I were honest I'd have to tell you I didn't like the P/E ratio, or the charts looked rotten, or whatever, and then you wouldn't want to buy. I couldn't get away with "I'm tired of this stock," or "I change my portfolio every two years," or "I'm moving away," which are the common excuses we use to sell each other our cars, houses, or furniture. A car sale or a house sale may benefit both parties in the transaction. In a stock trade, there's one winner and one loser, and it's soon obvious which is which.

Perhaps the official stock markets—the New York Stock Exchange and so forth—only exist to keep buyers and sellers from any direct contact, or else nobody would want to trade any stocks. Perhaps that's why each party in a stock deal engages a separate professional to interpret what is going on, so my broker can tell me "the smart money is holding on," while the seller's broker, with equal conviction, can congratulate his client for "dumping a dog."

These late-night suppositions had gone far enough. Since everything I'd heard about the stock market so far was secondhand, and some of it quite curious, I decided to travel to Wall Street to see for myself.